

Clothes and costumes



Leather and satin gloves

SWEET GLOVES

Fashionable ladies wore gloves scented with perfumes, such as musk and ambergris. In *Much Ado About Nothing*, Hero says, "These gloves the Count sent me; they are an excellent perfume."



17th-century diamond and amethyst necklace

COVERED IN JEWELS

Ladies covered themselves with glittering items of jewelry, including necklaces, rings, and earrings. They also wore diamonds and pearls sewn into their dresses, ruffs, hair, and shoes. The boy players wore cheaper costume jewelry made from glass because ladies would not have given away their valuable jewels.

Sleeves stuffed with bombast, or horsehair



FASHIONS FOR THE STAGE

Modern productions of Shakespeare's plays use clothes from many different periods of history. These 1920s designs for a production of *As You Like It* are early-1500s in style. Other productions of the play have been set in Victorian, Elizabethan, or modern times. In Shakespeare's day, the players often dressed extravagantly, which is one reason why people flocked to the playhouses. It wasn't important whether costumes were historically accurate because few people were aware of how fashions had changed throughout history.

PLAYERS IN SHAKESPEARE'S day always dressed in clothes of their own time. The late 1500s was a wonderful time for fashion. Noblemen and women paraded around like peacocks in spectacular outfits that were padded to create startling shapes and slashed to display extra colors and fabrics. There were strict laws about clothes, which were worn as a sign of rank. Nobody below the rank of baron could wear cloth of silver, and people caught dressing above their station could be arrested and locked in the stocks. Players were the only people who were allowed to break these laws, by dressing as nobles on stage.

Ruff made from lace

ALL PUFFED UP

Wealthy women in the late-16th century wore wide dresses with huge, padded sleeves. As a rule, the less practical the outfit, the higher the rank of its wearer. This dress is so impractical that its wearer, would have had to go through doors sideways!

Elizabeth Buxton by Robert Peake, c. 1589

Skirt held out by a farthingale frame

